

TerreStar Genus

TerreStar launches a \$799 Windows Mobile based phone called Genus; the phone has GSM backed with satellite capability

Blue Mickey

Blue Mickey is a condenser mic which is powered by AAA batteries which can charge cameras as well; it will hit the market next year at a price of \$69

depends on your daily usage scenarios, and what it is you're looking for. If a smaller screen and keyboard don't bother you, and if you're looking for longer battery life and more portability, a netbook should suffice. If you need a larger screen, and care more about PC performance than battery life, opt for a notebook. However, it's also a question of budget more often than not, and sometimes, all you can afford is a netbook!

Understanding the Atom CPU will help you make the choice if budget is not the major problem. The Atom may be capable of playing HD video (720p), but the screens on a netbook rarely support the resolutions you want. So forget about all that and think simplicity. If all you do is work on the occasional presentation or office document, and surf the net, you might not need anything more than a netbook. Forget about gaming, forget about anything more than DVD-quality video, and forget about being able to use optical media (DVDs/CDs). If you rarely use any of those anyway, get a netbook. For everyone else, a notebook is the solution.

THE TECH: AMD, Core i, Core 2 – confused, aren't you?

When it comes to laptops, the most hyped of all components are usually the CPU and the GPU – with good reason of course, since these are the star performers in every PC; portable or otherwise. However, just because a laptop has a CPU brand you've seen advertisements of on TV doesn't mean you're getting a good deal. The smartest thing to do is to find out which Core i, Core 2 or AMD CPU the laptop you're considering has. Never, and we repeat with emphasis, NEVER, go out and buy a laptop on your first outing. With so many model numbers and series from every manufacturer, it can all be very confusing. Just a letter extra at the end of a model number, or a series name being used instead of an actual model number could see you end up with something you're not happy with. Window shop, carry pen and paper, write down what you see, note exact model numbers and do your research on the model before you spend a single Rupee. Don't just look at models from one brand

either, keep your options open by looking at the offerings of at least three brands whose products you like and trust.

Also remember that certain PC and notebook versions of CPUs have the same model numbers – with just an "M" or some letter added somewhere to denote the notebook version, which actually consumes much less power, and performs much slower too. So watch out for that when looking up benchmarks online, and always make like-to-like comparisons.

As for GPUs, just re-read everything above and mentally replace CPU with GPU.

Out damned spot!

The bane of our existence, batteries have improved over the years, but barely enough to keep up with everything else. These are the proverbial spoil-sports, and honestly, take it from us, if you're planning long trips away from plug-points, and need to compute, get yourself some extra battery packs – netbooks, notebooks, tablets, smart phones, whatever, nothing is safe from the low battery monster when you're travelling. However, make sure to check rated battery times from reviews of the same model before you buy. It's always nice to boast of

high processing powers on your laptop, but if you can't get through a presentation or a long email without hooking it up to the mains, what is the point?

Ooh, shiny!

A lot of the laptops you'll see in malls have lovely shiny screens that can double as a mirror when they're off, but unfortunately, sometimes they can do the same when they're on as well. The advantage of a glossy screen over a matte one is that the glossy one, in the right conditions, will offer a better contrast ratio. This is usually good for when you're watching a video, but not when you try and do it in brightly lit conditions. You'd be lucky to see a thing if you're outdoors under direct sunlight if you have a glossy screen. What you need to do is decide based on your own usage, and if it's mainly indoors in dimly-lit conditions, choose a glossy screen, if it's mainly outdoors in the day, choose a matte-finished screen. Also, remember to check the resolution of the screen – very often you might be asked to pay more for a 13-inch screen that has the same resolution as a 12-inch. It's important that you get the highest possible resolution for your desired screen-size. Think HD! Trust us, you won't regret it.

RAM? HDD?

A lot of people ask us why their PCs are running slowly despite having 4 GB of RAM. Well, honestly, your laptop is only as fast as the slowest component. With a slow hard drive, there's only so much RAM can do to help speed things up. If you're not really bothered about battery-life, choose a 7200 rpm HDD, and at least 2 GB of RAM for your configuration. SSDs are also recommended for those who don't want loads of storage space. More than 4 GB of RAM has rarely shown us any significant performance improvements, so there's no need to go there, especially if you're running a 32-bit OS!

Keyboards and track-pads

The most important and yet the most over-looked parts of a laptop are the keyboard and track-pad. Cramped keyboards or those who have decided to be innova-

SERIES UNLINKED

Let's say Digit sold laptops, and we had a dGt 1000 series notebook. Now although we may have three actual models under this series – the dGt 1001, 1010 and 1100, we might choose to follow in all other manufacturer's footsteps and sell them all as the "dGt 1000" series. Of course we'd only ever advertise the features of the most powerful one – the dGt 1100 – and make sure all three models look identical to the untrained eye. Now, if you were to mistake our lowest model (the dGt 1001) for the 1100, that's hardly our fault, is it? So what if you thought you were getting a Blu-ray ROM drive and ended up with a DVD-writer? It's not like we didn't write the specs in fine print, and we can hardly be blamed for your poor eyesight and bad decision-making!

Although we were just having a bit of fun in the previous paragraph, you will not be if you cough up in excess of thirty thousand and end up with something other than what you paid for.